

Xbox 360) for around Rs 12,000 (street price). The package includes a Halo 1 DVD. Additional DVDs can be bought for around Rs 2,200 each, with Halo 2 and Doom III leading the sales charts.

The Xbox is the only legally available console in India, and retails for Rs 12,999 all inclusive. This is marginally higher than the grey market price, but there are no game disks. The game disks retail between two and four thousand rupees, depending on the game's fan following (as an example, Halo 2 retails for Rs 3,999).

The Sony PS3

Sony has a whole line-up of consoles, right from the PlayStation 1 (PS1) to the recently-launched and runaway success (half a million sold in the first week!) PlayStation Portable or PSP. Sony knows just how to position its consoles and price it just right. PlayStations also have the most comprehensive list of game titles (did we mention that you can't play games made for one console on the other?), which would satisfy even the most avid of gamers.

But with the PS3, Sony has outdone itself (or so the specifications suggest!)

No console has generated as much interest as has the Sony PS3. Recently showcased at E3 (see the *Enter* section in this issue for more), the power potential of PS3 is simply mind-numbing, the Cell processor being the main reason.

The showcasing was a complete brag show—as most showcases are—but the unveiled specs appear to be much better than those of the Xbox 360.

We have already mentioned the RAM and the Cell processor used before, so apart from all that, it features Dolby 5.1 Channel sound where the Cell processor doubles up as a sound card, and supports full-scale HDTV video out at 1920 x 1080i and 1280 x 720p.

It is also backward-compatible with the previous PlayStations (both 1 and 2). In terms of DVD support, it reads everything, from DVD+R, -R, +RW, -RW to Blu-Ray Disks. (Sony leads the consortium pushing it to make the entertainment standard). In fact, most PS3 titles are expected to be released on Blu-Ray.

Connectivity options are as extensive as the media reading capabilities. It has four front and two rear USB2.0 ports, as well as slots for Memory Stick Standard/Duo/Pro (that's pretty much all sizes!). Sony decided to stay out of pushing proprietary stuff for once, and also gave PS3 support for SD (Secure Digital), SD-mini and CF (Compact Flash) I and II memory cards.

In terms of networking capabilities, it supports wired networking as well as Wi-Fi 802.11 b/g, and Sony has thrown in Bluetooth for good measure. Interestingly, the controllers connect to the console using Bluetooth and not Wi-Fi, as is the case with the Xbox 360. This was done due to

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the lower latencies of Bluetooth as compared to Wi-Fi. You can connect up to seven controllers at once, so that's a great race right there!

An interesting implementation is that using Wi-Fi, you can connect your PlayStation Portable to your PS3 and thus have multiplayer without having to buy two PS3s!

In terms of availability, the PS3 is expected to be available in 2006. However, the other versions are available, and at a damn good price at that! You can buy the first PlayStation, PS1, for roughly Rs 3,800 (street price) with gaming titles for Rs 650 each.

The PS2 is for the serious gamers, and is available for Rs 10,000 (street price). The titles are more expensive at Rs 2,200 for a DVD.

A really great buy, however, is the PlayStation Portable, which is Sony's foray into the handheld gaming market. The PSP is dominated by a large 4.3 inch 16:9 widescreen TFT LCD with 480 x 272 pixel resolution displaying 130k colours. It has a USB2.0 port, Wi-Fi (strangely, no browser though), and utilises proprietary Sony media called UMD (Universal Media Disk), which can store up to 1.8 GB of data, and looks like a very cool mini disk.

Apart from the UMD (used for playing games, much like DVDs in the PS 1, 2, and 3) it also supports various Memory Stick types, and you can use those to listen to music or, in fact, watch a movie, so it does give you a complete entertainment solution right there in your hands!

Surprisingly, the PSP is excellently priced. We're quite sure Sony is selling it at a loss to firm up its market position. You can pick up a PSP for around Rs 11,500 (street price) which is, in fact, cheaper than what it retails for in the US—\$275, or Rs 12,375! Game titles are quite expensive, though, at Rs 2,200 a piece, but the sheer appeal of the device is worth shelling out 11 grand for!



The Sony PlayStation Portable (PSP)

Gamers have an insatiable appetite for a better, faster and a richer gaming experience and the manufacturers aren't letting them down either. They're creating devices that meet the gamers' requirements and in most cases, exceed them.

If you are into gaming and already own a PS2 or an Xbox, well and good, you need not really go and buy a PSP as well. But if you do not own an Xbox or a PlayStation yet, we suggest you wait a while and let the Xbox 360 and PS3 hit the markets because when they do, they will change the way you play games forever! ■

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